

# Phishing Detection & Awareness

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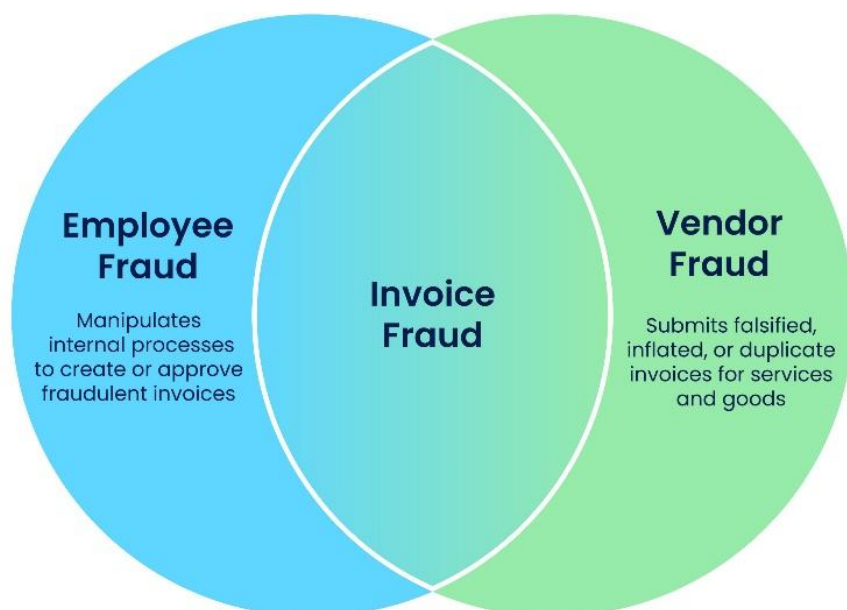
## Detailed Phishing Email Examples

- **Fake Vendor Invoice (Google & Facebook case)**

Attackers impersonated a legitimate hardware vendor and sent fake invoices. Even large corporations paid out over \$100 million before realizing the fraud. This shows how convincing phishing can be, even for experts.

### Why it worked

- Trust in a known vendor: Quanta Computer was a legitimate supplier, so invoices looked plausible.
- Sophisticated forgeries: Documents and emails mimicked real corporate communications.
- Large transaction environment: Google and Facebook routinely process huge payments, so unusual amounts didn't raise immediate suspicion.
- Social engineering pressure: Emails were crafted to look urgent and routine, bypassing deeper scrutiny.



- **Credential Harvesting Email**

A message claiming “Your Office 365 account will be disabled unless you verify.” The link led to a fake login page that captured usernames and passwords.

Sample Email (malicious)

From: security-alert@microsoft-support.com

Subject: Urgent: Account Access Suspended — Verify Now

Dear User,

We have detected unusual activity on your Microsoft account. For your protection, access has been temporarily suspended.

Please click the link below to verify your identity and restore access:  
[Verify My Account]

## Red Flags

- **Sender domain mismatch:** “micros0ft-support.com” looks similar to Microsoft but is fake.
- **Generic greeting:** “Dear User” instead of your actual name.
- **Urgency & fear tactics:** “Access suspended” pushes you to act quickly.
- **Suspicious link:** The “Verify My Account” button likely leads to a fake login page designed to steal credentials.

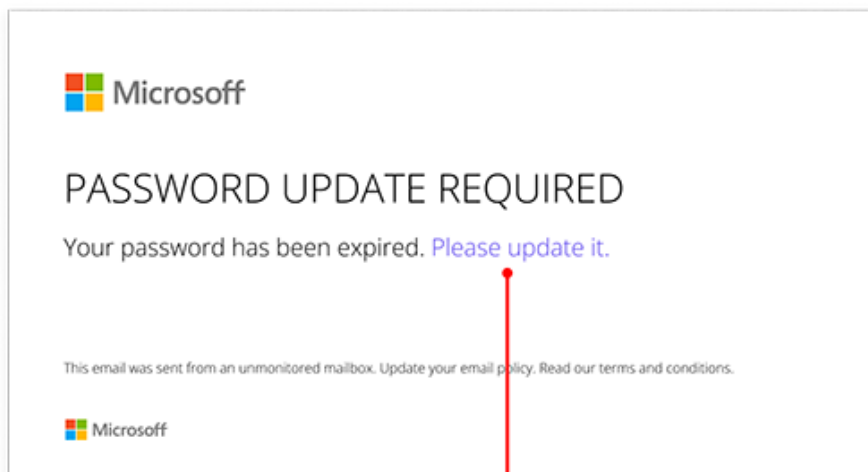
## Why It Worked

- **Urgency & Fear:** “Your account will be locked!” pushes quick action.
- **Authority & Familiarity:** Looks like it’s from Microsoft, Google, or your bank.
- **Convenience:** Easy “click here” link feels faster than logging in manually.
- **Look-alike Domains:** Fake addresses () trick rushed readers.
- **Professional Design:** Logos and formatting make it look real.
- **Lack of Awareness:** Many users don’t check sender domains or hover over links.



Low reputational external sender

 noreply@email.teams.microsoft.com  
Wednesday 15 July 2023 @ 11.01am



Browser exploit pack detected

- **Malware Delivery via Attachment**

Email disguised as a “shipping receipt” with a Word document attachment. Opening it triggered macros that installed malware.

### Red Flags

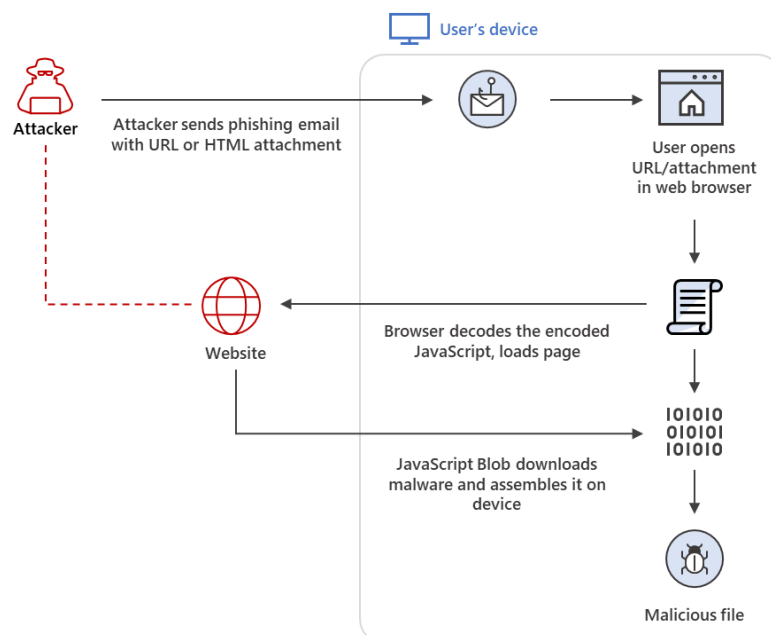
- **Unexpected attachment:** You weren’t expecting a salary report.
- **File type risk:** files can contain malicious macros.
- **Generic sender:** “hr@company-careers.com” may not match your real HR domain.
- **Sense of urgency:** “Confirm by end of day” pressures quick action.

### What Happens if Opened

- The Excel file may prompt you to “Enable Macros”.
- Once enabled, hidden code runs, installing malware (like ransomware or keyloggers).
- This gives attackers access to your system or network.

### What to Do

- Do not open unexpected attachments.
- Verify with HR or the sender using official contact info.
- Report the email to IT/security.
- If opened, disconnect from the network and run a malware scan immediately.

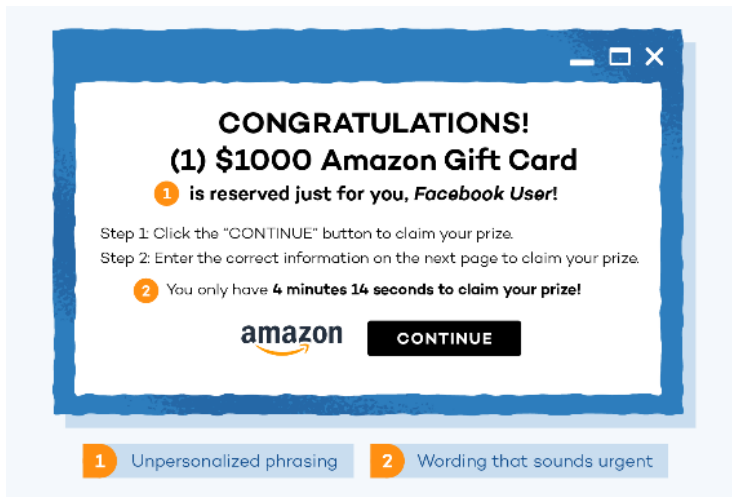


- **Prize Scam**

“You’ve won a \$500 Amazon gift card!” Clicking the link redirected to a malicious site that requested personal details.

### Why It Worked

- **Excitement & Greed:** The idea of “winning” blinds people to red flags.
- **Urgency:** “Claim within 24 hours” pressures quick action.
- **Authority Illusion:** Uses big brand names (Amazon, lottery) to appear legitimate.
- **Information Harvesting:** Tricks victims into giving personal or payment details.
- **Lack of Verification:** Many don’t stop to ask, “Did I even enter this contest?”



## Common Phishing Indicators

- **Domain Spoofing:** Attackers register lookalike domains (e.g., [micros0ft.com](https://micros0ft.com)).
- **Urgency & Fear:** “Your account will be locked in 24 hours.”
- **Unexpected Attachments:** Files disguised as invoices or receipts.
- **Generic Greetings:** “Dear Customer” instead of personalized names.
- **Grammar Errors:** Typos and awkward phrasing.
- **Too-Good-To-Be-True Offers:** Free prizes or rewards.

## Risk Classification

| Email Type          | Risk Level | Impact                                    |
|---------------------|------------|-------------------------------------------|
| Fake Vendor Invoice | High       | Direct financial loss (millions possible) |

|                           |        |                                           |
|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------------------|
| Credential Harvesting     | High   | Compromise of accounts, data breaches.    |
| Malware via Attachment    | High   | System infection, ransomware, data theft. |
| Urgent Account Suspension | Medium | Loss of credentials, account hijacking.   |
| Prize Scam                | Medium | Identity theft, malware installation.     |

## Simple Explanation of Attacks

Phishing emails are **tricks designed to fool you**. Attackers pretend to be trusted companies or colleagues. They use **fear (“your account will be locked”)** or **temptation (“you’ve won a prize”)** to make you click quickly. Once you do, they can steal your password, money, or install harmful software.

Think of phishing as a **digital con game** — the attacker’s goal is to make you act before you think.

## Prevention Guidelines

- **Pause Before Clicking:** Hover over links to see the real destination.
- **Verify Requests:** Call or email the company directly using official contacts.
- **Don’t Share Passwords via Email:** Legitimate companies never ask this way.
- **Report Suspicious Emails:** Use your company’s “Report Phishing” button or forward to IT.
- **Update Software Regularly:** Prevent malware exploits.
- **Enable Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA):** Adds a safety layer even if your password is stolen.
- **Train Employees Regularly:** Awareness campaigns reduce risk significantly.

## Awareness Takeaway

Phishing is **not just a technical problem** — it’s a **human problem**. Attackers exploit trust, fear, and curiosity. By learning the warning signs and practicing safe email habits, users can avoid becoming victims. Even the biggest companies have fallen for phishing, so vigilance is essential.